Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort at a pretty picture, **green** often appears at a moment when we want to **calm** something, let something **grow** or simply **rest** for a while. **The hand reaches for it before the brain can call a meeting**. Sometimes we know exactly why, sometimes not at all. **Both are fine**.

What may hide behind a green stroke

The same green line on paper can mean **something completely different every time**, depending on what is happening in us just then. Sometimes it is **calm**, sometimes **envy**, sometimes simply the taste of the colour. That is why there is no point in reading a picture like a test with **a single right answer**.

Longing for calm and a breath.

The stroke tends to be long, flowing and horizontal, like a meadow. The green is spilled out and nothing pushes it onward.

A need to grow and begin again.

The stroke heads upward, like stems and leaves. The colour spreads across the paper and claims space.

Caring for others.

Small regular strokes, like rows in a flower bed. Often around something or someone in the middle.

Envy and comparing.

A sharp, sour green, a narrow stroke, often next to another colour that it presses against and will not let go.

Tiredness and stagnation.

A matt grey-green, areas that do not change, a stroke that stops in the middle of the paper.

Nausea and oversaturation.

A yellow-green, unpleasant, sometimes even "green as bile". Like when you have had more than enough of something.

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Green in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, **it can**, but it does not have to. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Green can then give form to a longing for calm, growth or care, but also to envy or a feeling that you have had enough.

It can just as well be simply **a pretty colour** that you happened to have at hand that day. It gains meaning only in connection with your experience. A colour itself does not know what happened to you. **You do, or you will find out in time**.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters is not a single patch of colour but **the whole picture** and how it came to be. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting.

A predominance of green alone is not enough for a verdict on whether it is calm or tiredness. Maybe you wanted to rest. Maybe you simply enjoyed green so much that red had no chance that day.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A green picture and a green jumper may ask two completely different things of you. On canvas you give space to an experience. In clothing you may feel that the colour connects you with something that does not belong to you. **The canvas can carry everything you need to say in it**, and you do not have to buy anything new for that.

On canvas you can give it enormous space and you do not have to accept at the same time the idea of how you yourself will look in it. **Canvas can be a safe place** where you allow expression in your own way.

Sometimes you want to wear it, sometimes just paint it. Sometimes you enjoy pine needles on the windowsill and would not take a green jumper even as a raffle prize. **The two do not exclude each other**.

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When green takes over the space

First let it come. Maybe you reach for green and have no idea why. Let it appear on the canvas without any duty to explain whether it is calm, tiredness, envy or a memory of grandmother's garden. You can paint standing, on the floor, with your hand, a brush or a piece of cloth. What matters is what happens to you as you spread the colour, layer it or let it take up more room.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

A little leaf, or a whole forest?

A small green trace can be the centre of the whole picture for you. A large area can feel calm and spacious, or start to be too heavy. A large green area is not proof of great calm and a small trace does not mean you cannot rest.

- **SATURATION**

Saturated, or gentle?

A pure green can have the look of freshly washed grass. With white it turns into a soft sage or mint. With ochre or brown it gets closer to moss, bark or olives. If relief floods you after adding white, it is precisely that change that is interesting. Perhaps a less urgent look suits you today.

- **THICKNESS**

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push, spread and leave a trace in. Thin paint spreads, runs and can surprise you with a direction you did not plan. One time the substance and resistance please you, another time the chance to let go of control and watch what happens. It is not a test of courage.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the green stroke looks. More important is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life. **Two almost identical pictures can have a completely different story**. One was made after a long exhaustion, the other after the first spring day. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps after a while you will notice that you kept coming back to green in a period when you were missing **calm**, **space** or the wish to begin again. Perhaps you will link it with a completely different experience. In self-reflective work inspired by art therapy a picture can serve as **a trace of your own experience** and a chance to look back.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at a picture and it tells you nothing at all. And in a week, a month or a year it suddenly comes: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in myself then.” That is fine. **The picture is not running away**.

Neither is wrong and neither is right. Calm, growth, care and envy all belong to you, and green can **carry everything**.

If very strong or painful feelings appear while you paint, **do not stay with them alone**. Talk about them with someone close or with an art therapist or therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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